Don Quixote

A Comic Hero between Two Worlds

The two parts of *Don Quixote*, published in 1605 and 1615, together form what is arguably the first great modern novel in the Western literary tradition. Don Quixote himself is surely one of its greatest comic heroes. The novel is so full of insights, thoughtful jokes, and extraordinarily funny comedy that it remains a perennial work of Western literature and intellectual life.

It is a satire of the chivalric romances associated with an earlier age. Cervantes, like his contemporary Shakespeare, stands at a transition between older cultural forms and the beginnings of modernity. We see a movement from pastoral, chivalric, aristocratic literature toward a literature more accessible to the ordinary person, dealing with the problems that ordinary people encounter. The dragons have been brought down to human size, and in some respects so have the heroes.

The disjunction between appearance and reality is central to *Don Quixote*. Most readers know roughly what the knight and his squire, Sancho Panza, are like. Sancho generally sees ordinary things for what they are, while Don Quixote inflates the commonplace into the cosmic. He does not meet ordinary problems: he encounters enormous ones. Everyday experiences become events in a mythological world of heroic conflict.

Because he is so great-hearted, however, his version of reality has something to recommend it. He is mad and generally mistaken, yet the distortion is not without moral significance. Much of the humour and pathos comes from confusing the appearance he attaches to things with the reality that is actually there. The contrast between his intentions and the consequences of his behaviour gives us grounds both for laughter and for pity.

The novel offers a kind of binocular moral vision. We see through two perspectives: the mad knight who takes windmills for giants, and the practical squire who recognizes windmills. Don Quixote’s real enemy is not an evil knight, although that is what he often imagines. His enemy is the prosaic, mundane world itself. He is at odds with that world and tries to recreate it imaginatively in his own image.

He demands the right to live imaginatively. In practice, the right to reconfigure the world through imagination becomes the right to be wrong. That demand is a major source of the comedy, but it is also part of his heroism. He is a visionary and a madman, yet still a hero of sorts. The novel does not simply tell us to reject him because the practical person has a more accurate view.

The Knight, the Squire, and Dulcinea

Their mounts neatly symbolize their different dispositions. Don Quixote’s horse, Rocinante, is old and bony, hardly impressive as horseflesh. To him, however, it is a magnificent warhorse: no finer or more formidable steed has ever existed. Sancho, the plump, prudent, commonsensical man, rides a donkey. He thinks his donkey is a donkey, and he is right. But being right is not everything, and that is part of the novel’s message.

Don Quixote represents the idealist in us: the noble insistence that the world should be as it ought to be. Sancho is in some respects his alter ego, or our own other half, the

realistic element in us. He represents prudence and tangible reality. His emotions are more modest and reliable. The world he sees may not be glorious, but it is at least somewhat predictable and comprehensible. He speaks for common sense.

A third important presence, Dulcinea, is scarcely a participating character at all. Don Quixote elevates an ordinary woman, Aldonza Lorenzo, into the ideal lady of his chivalric imagination. She has little awareness of that role and does not appear as the ideal figure he describes. Her significance is to give him something to aspire to, something for which he can work and hope. His imagined beloved becomes the focus of his vocation.

By analogy, she represents something like what Goethe would later call “das Ewig-Weibliche,” the eternal feminine: an object of aspiration that draws a person onward. No one except Don Quixote understands why Dulcinea is so superlatively wonderful. To others she is an ordinary woman; to him she is everything. The explanation lies less in Dulcinea herself than in the imaginative life, and the madness, of the man who idealizes her.

Beyond the two principal figures, the novel has an enormous cast. Critics have even tried to count all the minor characters. Whatever the exact total, there are hundreds of encounters, and many people give Don Quixote something to fight, someone to be beaten by, or another occasion for misunderstanding. Their roles continually bring the contrast between appearance and reality into play.

Disguise is especially important. People appear in disguise, change their appearance, or are taken by Don Quixote to be disguised even when they are not. His interpretations are, to put it charitably, highly individual. He has a very unusual account of what is happening in the world. The multitude of characters allows Cervantes to repeat and vary this problem across many kinds of human experience.

The novel’s double perspective gives us an advantage. Realism offers prudence, predictability, and practical usefulness. Idealism offers more than noble intentions: there is a moral grandeur in trying to recreate the world in accordance with an aspiration. Something about it is deeply inspiring. Bringing the two visions together gives us the possibility of a view that is coherent and logical, yet still hopeful. That is one of the novel’s great achievements.

Romance, Madness, and the Shape of the Novel

The structure is less economical than a modern reader might wish. *Don Quixote* was an immediate success and was enjoyed in a culture where reading aloud mattered greatly. Its plot is expansive, sometimes ponderous, and seems to continue indefinitely. Depending on the edition, the two parts can run to more than a thousand pages. Like a long Dickens novel, it can make us wonder whether a firm editor might have removed some of the digressions.

Must we keep meeting shepherds and goatherds? Do we need every pastoral scene? Could some of this material have been left out? The first part contains numerous digressions, cross-references, and repetitions. The second is often regarded as the more accomplished of the two. I suspect that the acclaim of the first gave Cervantes greater confidence, allowing him to stay closer to the principal story while developing its implications more fully.

The plot is a kind of pseudo-epic. Instead of a superior hero performing deeds of unprecedented greatness, we have a minor country gentleman, a hidalgo, who becomes

convinced that he is a knight-errant. He is not imagining himself noble from an entirely non-noble position; he is transforming his modest social standing into a magnificent heroic vocation. He performs absurd deeds and believes them great. Despite their silliness, we may still find a measure of greatness in the aspiration behind them.

His madness begins with reading too many books of chivalry. These books tell him that the good life is the heroic life, the life of action and knight-errantry. He decides to follow the footsteps of the great men and become the great Don Quixote. Before that decision he is an unremarkable country gentleman. The change is rather like Walter Mitty's imaginary life, except that Don Quixote actually lives his fantasy in the world of space and time.

He loses his ordinary connection with reality, takes out the rusty armour of his ancestors, cleans it, mounts his supposed warhorse, and seeks deeds that will bring immortal fame. Everything he meets is altered by the story he tells himself. He may injure himself, harm somebody else, or achieve nothing at all, yet believe that he has accomplished something supremely important. The heroic imagination has become the principle by which he interprets his surroundings.

The Inn, the Windmills, and the Flocks

On his first outing he reaches an inn, which he takes for a castle. Its innkeeper becomes a noble lord, and the women he encounters there become ladies of quality. They are drawn into the chivalric story he is building around himself. He asks the innkeeper to confer knighthood on him. The man recognizes his madness and decides that the simplest way to get rid of him is to play along with the ceremony.

In keeping with the chivalric tradition, he intends to keep a vigil over his arms before being knighted. But the vigil causes so much disturbance that the innkeeper abbreviates it. In an informal paraphrase, his response amounts to: "That is enough preparation. I shall make you a knight now, provided you leave." The ritual confirms Don Quixote's heroic identity while serving the innkeeper's thoroughly practical desire to have peace restored.

Sancho joins him on a later outing and acquires difficulties of his own. Some come from following Don Quixote, which is itself a considerable hazard; others show that seeing the world realistically does not protect a person from suffering. Prudence and accuracy are useful, but they do not guarantee that events will go well. Sancho often has as many problems as his master. He is simply less mistaken about their source and nature.

Among the many adventures, the windmills are the most famous. Riding into a field, Sancho sees windmills. Don Quixote sees giants oppressing the land, enemies whose defeat will give him the opportunity for a great deed. He spurs Rocinante forward and attacks. His lance strikes a moving sail; the windmill throws horse and rider into disaster. The would-be conqueror of giants ends sprawled on the ground.

Sancho comes to help him, but the failure does not undo the knight's belief. Don Quixote explains it through enchantment. In paraphrase: "Sorcerers have been at work. I attacked giants, and an enchanter transformed them into windmills." What Sancho regards as the obvious fact becomes, for Don Quixote, the result of interference by a magical enemy. Experience is absorbed into the fantasy rather than allowed to disprove it.

Sancho must wonder what sort of knight he has entered into service with. Nevertheless, he stays. Despite his misgivings, he is willing to continue and see what happens, hoping not to suffer all the trouble his master brings upon himself. His fidelity is important. The practical man does not merely reject the imaginative man; he accompanies him, and their relationship makes both perspectives available to us.

Another adventure begins with clouds of dust in the distance. As they approach, Sancho recognizes flocks of sheep being driven by shepherds. Don Quixote sees invading armies. He imagines a battle that will allow him to defend the land and become its saviour. Single-handedly, he charges into the flock. Sheep are not formidable opponents for an armed rider, and he disperses and injures them while believing himself engaged in glorious combat.

The shepherds are understandably furious. They pelt him with stones and bring him down. Here his interference with the world has consequences for himself as well as for innocent people and animals. Sancho's realism cannot make their shared journey safe; he has to care for the battered knight and endure the aftermath. More generally, both men suffer in their travels. Accurate perception does not exempt the realist from the blows of life.

One possible message is that we shall take our knocks anyway. There is therefore something to be said for idealism even when it is unrealistic. That does not mean the harm is unimportant. Rather, Cervantes allows us to hold two judgments together: Don Quixote's actions can be foolish and damaging, while the aspiration behind them still possesses an attraction. The novel's double vision prevents either judgment from becoming the whole story.

Mambrino's Helmet and the Faith of Chivalry

The adventure of Mambrino's helmet offers another version of the same contrast. The legendary helmet belongs to the world of chivalric stories, with its promises of extraordinary glory. Don Quixote believes he has found it on the head of another knight. Naturally, this calls for combat. He will defeat the owner, obtain the helmet, and add a splendid achievement to the record of his knightly deeds.

Sancho sees something quite different: a barber riding between villages, wearing a brass basin on his head because it is raining and he wants to protect his hat. The animal is not a magnificent warhorse, and the rider is not a chivalric hero. The supposed helmet is simply a barber's basin. What matters is the mythic inflation by which Don Quixote makes these ordinary things into the elements of an extraordinary adventure.

Don Quixote wins, if one can call it a battle. The barber has no idea what is happening and flees, leaving the basin behind. The knight claims it triumphantly as Mambrino's helmet. It confirms his chivalric heroism in his own eyes. So long as he lives largely in imagination, he might as well possess the legendary object. The practical reality has not changed, but its meaning for him has been transformed.

Chivalry, for Don Quixote, resembles a religious commitment. It sustains a person and demands acts of faith. He lives that faith whether we find it sensible or ridiculous. This is why merely correcting an error of perception is not enough to explain his character. The imaginative world is bound up with his purpose in life. To give it up would be to surrender much more than a mistaken description of a basin or a windmill.

Anselmo, Lothario, and the Danger of Testing Trust

One of the most conspicuous digressions in the first part is the story of Anselmo and Lothario, read aloud at an inn. The name Lothario has since become a byword for a seducer or an unscrupulous ladies' man. When I first read *Don Quixote*, I wondered why this story was there. The book was already long, and the episode seemed to have little connection with the knight, his squire, or the theme of chivalry. On returning to it later, I found its possible meaning clearer.

Anselmo and Lothario are close friends. Anselmo is married to Camilla, but he wants proof of her fidelity. It is not enough that she has never been unfaithful. He reasons that, without an opportunity to betray him, her virtue has not truly been tested. He therefore asks Lothario to attempt to seduce her. He does not want the attempt to succeed; he wants a failed attempt that will certify the goodness of his wife.

The proposal can be paraphrased as follows: "I shall leave you the opportunity. Try to persuade her. If she accepts, I shall know that she is not faithful. If she refuses, I shall know that I have a virtuous wife." Lothario initially protests and tries to dissuade him. He understands that the experiment itself puts a good marriage in danger. Anselmo, however, persists. He insists on obtaining evidence where trust should have been sufficient.

At first Camilla is faithful, and Lothario does not immediately carry out the plan as Anselmo expects. But the husband's repeated insistence brings his friend into increasingly dangerous intimacy with her. Lothario becomes enamoured, and Camilla eventually returns his affection. The attempt to prove that betrayal is impossible helps to create betrayal. Anselmo's suspicion becomes the instrument of the very misfortune he wanted to exclude.

The lovers deceive him, and the appearances he treats as evidence become increasingly unreliable. They contrive scenes and explanations that seem to confirm Camilla's virtue while concealing the affair. The story ultimately ends in the ruin of all three. It is not merely an account of a wicked wife and an innocent husband. The husband's demand for certainty has altered the situation and helped destroy the relationship he was trying to secure.

The episode suggests that scepticism toward people whom we ought to trust can create problems rather than solve them. Anselmo demands the evidence of the senses, yet what he sees is manipulated. The senses alone cannot disclose good intentions or guarantee another person's fidelity. In that respect, the digression belongs with the novel's broader concern about appearance and reality, even though its characters are not participants in Don Quixote's adventures.

We might still question whether it deserves so much space. It could have made a striking separate tale. An editor might have proposed that Cervantes let it stand by itself. Yet there is an argument for retaining it, because its experiment in trust illuminates the dangers of relying on appearances. The episode illustrates both the digressive form of the first part and the possibility that an apparent digression carries a central intellectual theme.

The Wineskins, Intentions, and Consequences

The battle with the wineskins takes place while the inserted story is being read. Don Quixote is asleep at the inn, which he imagines as a castle. Dreaming of a giant, he slashes the wineskins stored in his room and takes the spilled wine for blood. He has won a magnificent battle in his imagination. The innkeeper, confronted with ruined skins and lost wine, has a very different view of the achievement.

The knight's conception of hospitality also causes difficulties. He imagines that a knight-errant should be welcomed because people recognize the importance of his calling. Ordinary bills therefore fit awkwardly into his chivalric world. But his companions and the innkeeper must deal with actual costs. The damage does not disappear because he did not intend it. Good intentions offer little comfort to the person whose property has been destroyed.

Philosophical readings of *Don Quixote*, such as José Ortega y Gasset's *Meditations on Quixote*, encourage us to look beyond the joke. A useful distinction is that we laugh at the knight's misadventures, but not simply at his intentions. His wish to defend the helpless and accomplish noble deeds is not what makes him contemptible. The comedy lies in the extraordinary distance between that wish and what actually happens when he acts upon it.

In this sense he is an idealist not only in the popular meaning of the word, but also in a moral sense that invites comparison with Kant. We consider the will and the intention, not only the results. His purposes can be noble even when the consequences are bad. That distinction does not absolve him from every responsibility, but it explains why our laughter need not destroy our affection. We can recognize folly without ceasing to admire generosity and courage.

The Second Part and the Knight of the Mirrors

Ten years passed between Cervantes' first part and his second. In 1614 an unauthorized continuation appeared under the name Alonso Fernández de Avellaneda. Cervantes responded to this rival in his own continuation of 1615. The false sequel gave him a further provocation to complete and publish his version, which I regard as the better part of the novel. It revisits the familiar misunderstandings, but gives them a more searching emotional and literary development.

At the foundation of much of the comedy is one recurring joke: the confusion of Don Quixote's understanding of reality with reality itself. We may be tempted to say that all comedy grows from mistaking appearance for reality. That would be too broad, but the contrast certainly explains a great deal of comedy here. The second part makes it more complicated because other people now deliberately work within the knight's delusions.

His friends want to bring him home and keep him there, but ordinary persuasion has failed. They therefore try to convince him, within the terms of his own fantasy, that he must return to a quiet life. Sansón Carrasco disguises himself as the Knight of the Mirrors, also associated with the name Knight of the Wood. He proposes a combat in which the defeated man must submit to the victor's demands. The plan depends on defeating Don Quixote without seriously harming him.

Unfortunately for the conspirators, Don Quixote wins. His victory defeats the attempt to cure him and encourages him to continue. One of the novel's ironies is that victories can hurt him as much as defeats. Success strengthens the convictions that expose him to

further danger. Perhaps the same is sometimes true of idealists more generally: a victory may preserve an illusion that failure might have challenged. He would, from his friends' practical perspective, have been better off losing.

The Wisdom of a Mad Knight

After defeating the Knight of the Mirrors, Don Quixote continues his travels and meets a gentleman whose son is a poet. Invited into their home, he discusses poetry and learning and says many wise things. The family confronts a perplexing combination: he is mad, yet remarkably intelligent. His appreciation of poetry also turns our attention back to Cervantes' own work. Imagination is not simply the opposite of understanding; it can be a means of insight.

Three observations, rendered here in modern language, illustrate the knight's wisdom. The first concerns wealth: "The possessor of riches is fortunate not simply because he has them, but because he spends them; and not because he spends as he pleases, but because he knows how to spend well." For someone so mistaken about windmills and basins, this is a surprisingly acute distinction. Possession alone is not the good; the wise use of what one possesses matters.

A second observation compares life with the theatre: "Some play emperors, others popes, and others all the roles that can appear in a play. But when the play of life ends, death strips away the garments that distinguish them, and they are equal in the grave." The remark becomes especially poignant because Don Quixote will himself end the novel in the grave. Death restores an equality that does not necessarily express the differences between the lives people have lived.

A third observation comes from his advice to Sancho about governing: "If you should bend the staff of justice, let it be not under the weight of a bribe, but under the weight of mercy." This is a beautiful, humane sentiment. The apparently deluded knight can offer intelligent advice about political responsibility. His compassion is not destroyed by his madness; it is part of the moral integrity that survives the foolishness of his adventures.

He is often wrong, but he is not fundamentally malicious. That is why the comparison between intention and consequence remains important. His nobility comes partly from maintaining a generous core while struggling against impossible odds and imaginary enemies. We need not believe that every action is harmless in order to recognize that core. The wise sayings complicate the easy judgment that a madman can have nothing valuable to tell us.

The Lions and the Puppet Theatre

A striking example of physical courage occurs in the adventure of the lions. Don Quixote encounters a wagon carrying caged lions intended for the king. Here he recognizes the animal for what it is. He nevertheless insists that the keeper open the cage so that he can face it. There is no practical need for the challenge. He is seeking glory, and a lion seems a worthy opportunity to prove his courage.

The cage is opened, but the lion does not cooperate. It stretches, yawns, turns away, and shows no interest in fighting the knight. The anticlimax is wonderfully comic. Don Quixote has put himself in danger, yet nature refuses to supply the grand encounter he wants. The lion is simply a lion, with concerns of its own, not an actor obliged to take a part in his heroic narrative.

Although no battle takes place, we have little reason to deny his courage. He was prepared to face the animal. Whether, in his own imagination, that already counts as a victory is another question. The incident illustrates the nobility that can survive, or even be strengthened by, his madness. He adopts the title Knight of the Lions, giving an uneventful refusal by the animal a place in the story of his achievements.

The episode can also be read against the background of medieval heroic literature. The *Cantar de mio Cid*, a major Spanish epic, includes a famous scene in which the Cid calmly subdues an escaped lion while others are terrified. Cervantes' scene offers an ironic variation on such heroic tests. We should distinguish that comparison from a literal claim that the Cid bore Don Quixote's title. The continuity lies in the literary motif, while the difference lies in the absence of the expected combat.

Less formidable opponents await him in the puppet theatre. Earlier, he has freed a group of condemned galley prisoners, believing that his calling requires him to oppose their captivity. These are not simply innocent victims, and his intervention has troublesome consequences. One of them, Ginés de Pasamonte, reappears under the identity of Master Pedro, a puppeteer. He makes his living through performances and a supposedly fortune-telling ape.

The ape's powers depend on deception and the credulity of its customers, another small comedy about appearance and reality. The puppet show likewise becomes a source of confusion. It depicts a rescue and the pursuit of the escaping lovers by Moors. Don Quixote cannot maintain the distinction between representation and action. He thinks the figures need his help, draws his sword, and cuts the puppets to pieces.

Once the damage is apparent, he makes apologies and pays compensation. His explanation still involves enchanters, but the incident allows a moment of recognition. He has mistaken a spectacle for reality and injured the livelihood of the man presenting it. The episode also reveals a change in the tone of the second part. The knight's confidence is less secure, and our response increasingly includes sympathy for his confusion rather than uncomplicated laughter.

Disenchantment becomes a growing element of the story. We begin to feel the pain of a man who is no longer protected quite so completely by his illusion. Earlier, he could turn failure into another proof of magic. Now the possibility that his understanding is unreliable presses more heavily upon him. Pathos enters alongside comedy. He remains good-hearted, but the imaginative world that sustained him is increasingly exposed to damage.

Cruel Jokes and Sancho's Government

At the residence of a duke and duchess, Don Quixote becomes the object of elaborate practical jokes. His reputation as a mad but entertaining knight has spread, and people deliberately exploit his gentleness and credulity. They pretend to accept his chivalric world in order to manipulate it. As the jokes become more cruel, our pity increases. The supposedly sensible people begin to look morally less admirable than the man they ridicule.

One consequence of the stay is that Sancho obtains the opportunity he has long wanted: to be a governor. He is sent to Barataria, described to him as an island but actually a settlement used for the duke's joke. His appointment is contrived, yet his responsibilities bring out real qualities. The man whom others expect to be a fool proves capable of wise, just, and humane decisions.

Sancho develops considerably in the second part. The practical man has absorbed something from his companion’s idealism. His judgments show insight and forethought that others did not expect. Don Quixote’s counsel about compassion and justice has not been wasted. What began as a contrast between the idealist and the realist becomes a relationship in which each can change the other. The novel’s double vision is not static.

Although Sancho is made the butt of jokes, he turns out to be a wise fool. Eventually he decides that government is not the life he wants and leaves the post. He returns to Don Quixote. In the interpretation I am proposing, his real vocation is not to rule the supposed island but to accompany the knight. He has discovered something about his own capacities and, more importantly, about what kind of life is worth choosing.

Disenchantment and the Knight of the White Moon

As Sancho becomes more admirable, Don Quixote moves closer to the everyday reality the reader recognizes. In the course of this movement, his adventures lose some of their earlier enchantment. A herd of bulls rushes along the road and knocks the travellers down. He recognizes the animals as bulls, not dragons or mythical enemies. From the practical perspective, that is an improvement. From the perspective of his imaginative life, it signals a loss.

The distinction matters because his heroism has depended on making the ordinary into something extraordinary. When he can no longer do that as confidently, he is not becoming wicked, but he is losing the world in which his vocation made sense. We feel that something essential is ebbing. The adventures become less a sequence of laughable mistakes and more the gradual erosion of a sustaining illusion.

He also quarrels with Sancho over the lashes that Sancho is supposed to give himself to secure Dulcinea’s disenchantment. When Don Quixote tries to enforce the punishment, Sancho resists and overpowers him. They reconcile, but the reversal is significant: the squire can now master the knight. Sancho is no longer merely an auxiliary figure. His strength and independence have grown while his master’s authority is becoming less secure.

The decisive defeat comes at the hands of the Knight of the White Moon. This is Carrasco in another disguise, still trying to make Don Quixote return home. The condition of the encounter is that, if defeated, the knight must give up wandering and remain at home for a year. This time Carrasco succeeds. Don Quixote accepts the obligation, although he does not abandon his belief in Dulcinea’s perfection. His fidelity survives, but his public life as a knight has been interrupted.

This defeat is less straightforwardly funny than earlier mishaps. He knows that he has lost. Later, a herd of pigs tramples the travellers, and once again the animals remain ordinary animals in his account. They are not promoted into mythological adversaries. In the reading developed here, the loss of that imaginative transformation accompanies the decline of Don Quixote himself. We see the hero’s world shrinking toward the scale of common experience.

Alonso Quijano and the Inheritance of Hope

Back at home, he falls ill with a fever and eventually declares that he is no longer Don Quixote. He is Alonso Quijano, the man he was before taking up knight-errantry, known as Alonso the Good. He renounces the books of chivalry and recognizes the error into which they led him. His goodness has not vanished with the change of name. It was there throughout his madness and remains present in his return to ordinary identity.

He wishes his story to be a warning against the books that misled him. Yet the return of sanity also becomes a sign of approaching death. In a deliberately paradoxical formulation, we might say that a fatal delirium of sanity kills Don Quixote. The fever belongs to the literal story; the deeper literary point is that, when the imaginative idealist disappears, the life of Don Quixote disappears with him. The ordinary name returns, but the extraordinary vocation can no longer continue.

His friends gather at his deathbed in one of the novel's most moving scenes. He makes his will, wishes his obligations settled, and recognizes Sancho's faithful service. His niece is the principal heir to his property; Sancho is allowed to retain money after the settlement of what is owed to him. The important inheritance for our interpretation is therefore not that Sancho receives the entire estate, but that he becomes the knight's spiritual heir.

Sancho begs him not to die. He urges him to get up and go into the fields, taking up the pastoral life they had imagined after the defeat. They might still find Dulcinea restored to her beauty. The realistic squire now calls upon imagination to keep hope alive. His plea can be paraphrased: "Do not give up. Let us go out together once more." The man who once explained that windmills were windmills now resists the final surrender to ordinary fact.

Sancho has become more heroic and admirable, not by ceasing to be himself, but by absorbing something of his master's spirit. Don Quixote is dying, yet the idealism that animated him has not simply ended. It lives in the squire who refuses to believe that defeat must be final. This is what makes Sancho a spiritual heir. The relationship has carried the knight's imaginative generosity into another person's life.

The body dies, but the spirit lives on in Sancho and in the novel. It is the spirit of heroism, idealism, and imagination: the attempt to make the world accommodate aspiration rather than merely making the mind accommodate the world. The transformation invites comparison with religious images of a life that survives bodily death. Here that immortality is literary and spiritual. Don Quixote continues wherever his story renews the possibility of hope.

I would not necessarily call the final scene tragic in the strict sense, but its pathos is extraordinary. A great comic artist must be able to do more than make us laugh. The ability to move us is almost a test of that greatness. Many writers can produce a joke; the greatest can make us laugh and then make us weep over the same person. Cervantes' ending shows how close comedy can come to the deepest sources of feeling.

Comedy and the Affirmation of Life

There are many ways of reading *Don Quixote*. I would emphasize the way it undermines our sense of futility. Our aspirations may be frustrated, yet they can retain spiritual grandeur. Failure does not make every effort worthless. Despite our failings, our striving can ennoble us, and that is an important part of life. The novel asks us to see more in the person who hopes than the record of what his hopes have achieved.

It also reminds us that great comedies remain possible, in literature and in life. We might wonder whether our age still permits heroes of the scale required by tragedy and epic, whether anyone is quite large enough for those forms. That is a question rather than a final judgment on modern literature. But comic heroes remain possible. The discrepancy between what we hope for and what happens still gives imagination something to work with.

Life still requires affirmation, then as now, and hope remains a virtue. Don Quixote reminds us of what we were like before we succumbed to experience: before disappointment became the only standard by which we measured aspiration. We need not become blind to reality in order to learn from him. His story lets realism and idealism speak to one another, and leaves room for a life that is prudent without being stripped of hope.